



SHANTI, 10

Married at 5, widowed at 7,
Pander village, Bhilwara

"Many justify child marriage as a means to escape expenses whereas early widowhood brings back the burden of raising the girl and marrying her off again."

DINESH SONI, COORDINATOR, PRAYAS



MEERA MALI, 18

Married at 7, widowed at 14,
Duni village, Tonk



MANJU SHARMA, 21

Married at 13, widowed at 16,
Duni village, Tonk

own parents. She now lives in the same village as her in-laws, Sihana, but separately in a small dwelling, works with them in fields and gets grain in return. "Life will be better once my son grows up and settles down," she says, her eyes moist. But there's a cruel cut in there too. She will not be allowed to perform her son's wedding ceremonies. "That will be the worst time of my widowhood," she says.

Seema Tiwari, 20, of Duni village in Tonk district, a widow to typhoid at 16 when her only child, a son, was three months old, is learning how bad things could be. Her Brahmin community does not accept widow remarriage. "I am not keen on it either," she says, in obvious connection to her four-year-old son. Hounded out by her in-laws and then by her parents, cut off from any inheritance, Seema rented a small room. Just as she enrolled in the National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme (NREGS) to earn a living, her landlord asked her to vacate the house.

The stigma just doesn't go, as Manju Sharma, 21, also of Duni village, has learnt. Married at 13, when she was in Class V, she became a widow three years later, losing her husband Ram Babu Sharma, 17, in an accident. His younger brother Ganesh, who runs a small restaurant, was married to Manju's younger sister. While Manju's in-laws kept her with themselves, her sister, who was

against her staying with them, left her husband, Ganesh, and child in protest. Manju's in-laws have even taken up the issue of remarriage with caste leaders. She refuses, and her in-laws have encouraged her to study. Manju is in Class XII now. "I am not keen to remarry, as I may not get a family like this," she says.

Divorce makes things worse. Take Seema Raigar, 23, of Kekri in Ajmer district, was married at four, and went to live with her husband at 15. Seema was socially divorced at 18, and later sent on nata to Ramesh in Charond village in Tonk. There she had a daughter, who died within a year of birth. Sometime later, her husband passed away suddenly. Seema suffers a physical disability, and her in-laws refuse to support her. Now she works as a farm labourer and lives with her father Hans Raj.

The state Government gives widows a

pension of Rs 400 per month, but the parents of many child widows do not apply for it, fearing the repercussions of admitting a child marriage. The official policy doesn't have any minimum age limit. INDIA TODAY could not find a child widow getting pension before 18.

Child widows do not get to work in government schemes either, since employing anyone less than 18 is barred, including in the NREGS. Many grown-up child widows—like Santra Devi, 22, of Kekri, or Nathi Kumawat, 20, of Sheopura in Ajmer—have not even applied, though some who are over 18 are availing such benefits.

Mahendra Bhardwaj, officer on special duty to the Rajasthan chief minister, says a panchayat sensitive to such child widows can find many ways to help them. For example, Bhanwar Lal Chaudhry, sarpanch of Duni village, besides getting Seema work under NREGS, helped her get a piece of land as she had no place to live. Manphool gets a monthly widow pension of Rs 400 and Rs 675 to raise her child under a government scheme.

Even such nominal help is reaching only a fraction of victims of child marriages. The lack of will to battle this custom runs like a thread through political parties and religious organisations, as no one wants to speak against it.

It's a long dark tunnel for thousands of child widows, and no end in sight. Not yet. ■